EDITORIAL SERIES · WHAT COUNTS IN THE AGE OF AI? · PART 5 OF 10

What Counts as Expertise in the Age of AI?

As AI makes expert answers and procedures increasingly accessible, this editorial argues that expertise resides less in producing convincing outputs than in exercising judgement: deciding what matters, evaluating evidence, understanding context, and accepting responsibility.

By Dr Jabreel Asghar · 1 September 2026

Yesterday I was reviewing the draft of an assessment rubric with a colleague. He was concerned that each assessment criterion should clearly demonstrate the intended course learning outcomes. I explained how I had developed the rubric before adding that I had asked an AI assistant to review the completed draft for alignment with the CLOs. He immediately relaxed. "Then we're ready for the next stage," he said.

His response stayed with me. It was not simply that AI had checked the document. It was that the AI review appeared to provide the reassurance that my own professional judgement alone had not. Increasingly, we seem to treat AI confirmation as a marker of quality in its own right.

We often hear that AI democratizes expertise by making expert knowledge available to everyone. Yet this assumes that expertise consists primarily of possessing answers. Increasingly, AI can explain concepts, analyse documents, identify inconsistencies, and even evaluate work against explicit criteria. If those tasks become widely accessible, what remains distinctive about expertise?

AI has made expert answers—and increasingly expert procedures—abundant. What remains comparatively scarce is expert judgement: deciding which questions matter, recognising when rules are insufficient, weighing competing considerations, understanding context, and accepting responsibility for decisions whose consequences extend beyond the evidence immediately available. AI has made expert performance easier to reproduce. It has not made expert judgement equally easy to acquire.

Perhaps this is because we have long confused expertise with its visible outputs. We see the diagnosis, not the years of clinical reasoning behind it. We see the published paper, not the countless decisions about which evidence to trust and which arguments to discard. We see the assessment rubric, not the professional judgement that determined what students should actually be assessed on.

For much of history, that confusion hardly mattered. Access to expert knowledge was limited. Experts usually possessed both knowledge and judgement, so it was easy to assume that the knowledge itself was what made them experts. When someone consistently produced good answers, we naturally attributed expertise to the answers rather than to the thinking that produced them.

AI has disrupted that assumption.

Today, many of the visible products of expertise can be generated within seconds. Explanations, summaries, lesson plans, legal drafts, research reviews, computer code, policy documents, and assessment rubrics no longer require years of training simply to produce a competent first version. The performance has become easier to reproduce, even when the underlying expertise has not.

This is precisely why the debate about AI replacing experts often misses the point. It focuses on whether AI can produce outputs that resemble expert work. Increasingly, it can. The more important question is whether producing those outputs is what expertise actually consists of.

I would argue that it never was.

Expert judgement begins before the answer appears. It begins with deciding what problem is really being solved. It involves recognising which evidence deserves greater weight, identifying assumptions that should be questioned, understanding what matters in a particular context, and accepting responsibility for choices that cannot be reduced to a set of rules. Those decisions are rarely visible in the final product, yet they are often what determine its quality.

Ironically, AI may be making expert judgement more valuable rather than less. As competent answers become increasingly abundant, the ability to evaluate those answers becomes increasingly scarce. When almost everyone can generate plausible solutions, the competitive advantage shifts from producing information to judging its quality.

This has important implications for higher education. If universities continue rewarding students primarily for producing answers, they risk assessing the very capability that AI is becoming increasingly good at replicating. The more difficult educational challenge is to develop and assess judgement: asking better questions, evaluating competing claims, recognising uncertainty, defending decisions, and knowing when a convincing answer should not be accepted at face value.

Perhaps that has always been the true purpose of higher education. AI has not changed what expertise is. It has simply exposed what expertise was all along.

About this editorial

As AI makes expert answers and procedures increasingly accessible, this editorial argues that expertise resides less in producing convincing outputs than in exercising judgement: deciding what matters, evaluating evidence, understanding context, and accepting responsibility.

Cite this editorial

Asghar, J. (2026, September 1). What counts as expertise in the age of AI? Dr Jabreel Asghar. https://jabreelasghar-website.vercel.app/insights/what-counts-as-expertise-in-the-age-of-ai

© 2026 Dr Jabreel Asghar. This editorial may be shared or quoted with appropriate attribution. Substantial reproduction, adaptation, or commercial reuse requires permission.

Part 5 of 10 in the series What Counts in the Age of AI?

Previous editorial · Published

What Counts as Teaching in the Age of AI?

Next editorial · Forthcoming

What Counts as Assessment in the Age of AI?

Read the online edition